FIELD GUIDE

no cap

aura farming

rizz

LORE

2026 THE SOCIAL MEDIA LEXICON

EXPANDED EDITION

delulu

slop

algospeak

cooked

lock in

A practical guide to new terminology, slang, platform features, and the language of online culture.

From Lore to Slop, Rizz to Algospeak — decode the internet of 2026.

ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

2026

FIELD GUIDE

The Social Media Lexicon

EXPANDED EDITION

A Practical Guide to New Terminology, Slang, Platform Features, and the Language of Online Culture

ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

COMPILED OCTOBER 2026

About this edition

Compiled October 2026 from current trends, platform documentation, and cultural analysis. Slang moves faster than any reference book, so definitions are synthesized for practical use and may continue to shift.

How to read an entry

Every dictionary entry carries a colored theme label, the term, a plain-language definition, and — where one was supplied — an example of the term in use. Entries are alphabetical; to browse by theme instead, turn to Browse by Theme near the end of the book.

Dating & Relationships · Maxxing & Glow-Ups · Put-Downs & Shade · Praise & Hype · Crypto & Money · Platforms & Algorithms · Internet Culture & Memes · Reactions & Texting · Mindset & Lifestyle

Three small flags appear on some entries:

- **ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE** — the term circulated in those communities long before it went mainstream. Credit matters; see Chapter 5.
- **DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE** — an insult, included so you can recognize it, not to encourage its use.
- **EMERGING · THIN SOURCING** — a niche or very recent term drawn from trend coverage and search spikes. Treat the definition as provisional.

Repeated entries in the source material have been merged, and the quick-reference abbreviations have been given full entries so everything can be found in one A–Z sequence.

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Introduction

Social media manufactures language at industrial speed. In 2026 terms can move from a TikTok comment to brand campaigns and dictionary shortlists in months. This expanded lexicon is a practical field guide to the vocabulary shaping feeds, comments, group chats, and culture right now.

The drivers are consistent: platforms reward fast recognition, algorithms surface pattern-matching content, and users invent shorthand that works for both humans and machines. Many durable terms have deeper roots in African American Vernacular English (AAVE), Black and Latino ballroom culture, gaming, and earlier internet dialects. TikTok and short-form video remain the primary accelerators, while Instagram, X, YouTube Shorts, Threads, and others circulate the same lexicon.

Origins and credit matter. Words such as slay, no cap, bussin, period, tea, and shade circulated in AAVE and ballroom communities long before they became mainstream Gen Z slang. Using them accurately includes acknowledging those roots. Algospeak — distorted forms such as “unalive,” “seggs,” or “corn” — shows how platform rules force language to adapt around filters and penalties.

This edition expands every chapter with more terms, deeper context, and 2026-specific platform changes (including user-controlled algorithm tools). Chapter 1 covers defining cultural words. Chapter 2 is a broader slang dictionary. Chapter 3 covers platform features and the new wave of algorithm controls. Chapter 4 expands metrics, content concepts, and algospeak. The final chapter adds cultural notes and practical advice for staying current.

CHAPTER

01

The Language of 2026

Words of the Year and Cultural Shifts

2026 SPOTLIGHT

Emerging Terms to Know

These terms rose sharply in 2026 according to social listening (Sprout Social), search data (Preply, Unscramblerer), and coverage of Gen Z / Gen Alpha language. They are listed here for quick reference; full entries appear alphabetically in the dictionary.

Lore	Word of the Year; background story or personal history.
Slop	Low-quality AI-generated content.
Niche	Specialized community as a badge of honor.
Maxxing	Maximizing a trait or activity.
Polyester	Cheap, synthetic, or over-polished.
Influencer Fatigue	Weariness with paid influencer content.
Lowkenuinely	Sincere, calm truth-telling.
Boy kibble	Simple high-protein meal.
The saxophones are getting louder	Escalating absurdity or inevitable negativity.
Quiet on the creek	Keep something private.
Mbappé special	Literally nothing.
Scuba	Something stinks.
Crine	Extremely funny (misspelled crying).
Aura farming	Deliberately building coolness.
6-7	Nonsense meme phrase.
GM	Good Morning.
NGMI	Not Gonna Make It.
WAGMI	We're All Gonna Make It.

Sprout Social's analysis of public posts named Lore the 2026 Social Media Word of the Year after more than 10 million mentions. The ranking captures a real shift: audiences are moving away from pure surface content toward narrative, history, and context. Parallel high-volume terms map resistance to low-effort AI output, preference for smaller communities, and appetite for chaotic authenticity.

Spotlight: the words behind the shift

10M+ MENTIONS

Lore

Deep personal, cultural, or historical backstory and narrative context. The viral pattern "realising your friend has lore" became a common reaction when someone revealed an unexpected past. Brands have already used the idea; McDonald's lore-inspired campaign drawing on The Backrooms mythology generated millions of views and high engagement. Lore rewards depth over quick hits.

> *"Wait, you used to tour with a band? You have serious lore."*

8.8M MENTIONS

Slop / AI Slop

Low-quality, mass-produced content generated largely by AI with little human judgment, originality, or care. With roughly 8.8 million mentions, the term captures widespread pushback against synthetic filler that floods feeds. Related insults include "that's so AI," "polyester" (cheap or over-polished), and "meat proxy" (someone who forwards AI content without engaging with it).

> *"The entire Explore page is slop today."*

4M+ MENTIONS

Niche

A smaller, interest-specific community or corner of the internet. In 2026 it functions as a badge of honor — people deliberately retreating from algorithm-driven mass feeds into shared-interest spaces. Mention volume exceeded 4 million. Niche communities often feel more human and less optimized for pure engagement.

4.6M MENTIONS

Unhinged

Chaotic, wild, or deliberately unpolished energy, frequently applied to brand voice. Consumer brands such as Grillo's Pickles used the style successfully (one stunt generated millions in earned media value). Roughly 4.6 million mentions. Unhinged content can feel more authentic than polished corporate messaging.

OPTIMIZATION CULTURE

Maxxing and Aura Culture

The act of optimizing something to the maximum. Originating in online appearance communities (looksmaxxing), the suffix now attaches to many domains: auramaxxing, sleepmaxxing, etc. Media coverage of optimization culture was extensive. Aura itself refers to coolness, charisma, or presence. Aura farming is the deliberate (but supposedly effortless) cultivation of that presence, often on camera. Aura points are the imaginary score. Aura battles have moved offline in some regions of Latin America and elsewhere.

> *"He scored and walked away without looking back — pure aura farming."*

Other notable 2026 cultural terms

- **Polyester** — Figurative critique of anything cheap, synthetic, or over-polished.
- **Influencer Fatigue** — Audience weariness with paid promotional content.
- **Episodic** — Preference for multi-part, serialized brand storytelling that feels closer to television.
- **Corecore / sludge content** — Emotional or oddly addictive low-effort video styles.
- **Boy kibble** — Simple high-protein meals (often ground meat and rice) that went viral as a food format.

CHAPTER

02

Essential Slang Dictionary

More than 230 terms, A to Z

The following terms are in active use across TikTok, Instagram, X, Discord, texting, and group chats in 2026. Definitions are practical; usage is often playful, ironic, or context-dependent. Many function as both compliment and light insult depending on tone. Abbreviations are included where they dominate.

#

3 TERMS

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

304

Derogatory for promiscuous (calculator upside-down).

> *"She's a 304."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

PRAISE & HYPE

4+4

Means "ate" (4+4=8).

> *"She 4+4 that look."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

6-7 / Six seven

A nonsense meme phrase popularized in 2026. Frequently searched yet meaning almost nothing.

> *"The comments were just 6-7."*

A

8 TERMS

CRYPTO & MONEY

Airdrop

Free tokens or items distributed to users.

> *"Claim the airdrop."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Algospeak

Distorted language used to evade platform filters and penalties, such as "unalive," "seggs," or "corn." See Chapter 4.

CRYPTO & MONEY

Alpha

Early or exclusive information.

> *"Got the alpha."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Alpine Divorce

Dramatic personal breakup or situation (niche 2026).

> *"That was an Alpine Divorce."*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

CRYPTO & MONEY

Anon

Anonymous user.

> *"Anon said..."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Arc

Narrative or personal journey.

> *"She's in her villain arc."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Ate / Ate and left no crumbs

Performed exceptionally well; left nothing to criticize.

> *"She ate that routine and left no crumbs."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Aura / Aura points / Aura farming

Aura is coolness, charisma, or presence; aura points are the imaginary score. Farming is the deliberate (but supposedly effortless) cultivation of it. See Chapter 1.

> *"He scored and walked away like nothing happened — pure aura farming."*

B

16 TERMS

CRYPTO & MONEY

Bagholder

Someone stuck holding a losing asset.

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Ballhog

Someone who takes all the attention or credit.

> *"Stop being a ballhog."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Based

Authentic, unapologetic, or admirable in an independent way.

> *"That's so based."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Bed rotting

Spending long periods in bed, usually scrolling or resting, sometimes framed as self-care or burnout.

> *"I'm bed rotting all weekend."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Benching

Keeping someone as a backup option.

> *"I think he's benching me."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Bet

Agreement, confirmation, or "okay / for sure."

> *""You free later?" "Bet.""*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Beta

Test version or less dominant person.

> *"He's beta."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Big W

Significant win.

> *"Big W today."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Bird

Derogatory term for a girl seen as foolish or overly focused on men.

> *"She's such a bird."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Blackpilled

Nihilistic or hopeless worldview.

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Bluepilled

Still believing mainstream narratives.

> *"Bluepilled take."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Boy kibble

A viral, simple high-protein meal format, typically ground meat and white rice.

> *"Meal prepping boy kibble again."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Brainmaxxing

Trying to maximize intelligence or knowledge.

> *"Brainmaxxing with podcasts."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Brainrot

Mental fog from consuming too much low-quality or addictive internet content. Also used for the content itself.

> *"That series gave me full brainrot."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Breadcrumbing

Giving just enough attention to keep someone interested without commitment.

> *"Stop breadcrumbing me."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Bussin

Extremely good, usually about food.

> *"That meal was bussin."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE



24 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Cancelled

Publicly shamed or rejected for behavior or opinions.

> *"They got cancelled."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Cap / No Cap

Cap = a lie or exaggeration. No cap = for real, no lie.

> *"That was the best concert of my life, no cap."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Careermaxxing

Intense focus on career advancement.

> *"Careermaxxing hard."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Caught in 4K

Caught clearly in the act (often with evidence).

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Character development

Personal growth over time.

> *"That's character development."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Chat is this real

Streamer expression of disbelief or surprise.

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Chopped

Ugly or unattractive.

> *"That fit is chopped."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Chronically online

Deeply immersed in internet culture.

> *"Chronically online take."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Chud

Insult for a loser or unpleasant person (with online connotations).

> *"Don't be a chud."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Chudmaxxing

Ironic or pejorative for maximizing unattractiveness.

> *"Don't chudmaxx."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Clanker

Mocking insult for robots, AI, or automated things.

> *"Stop being a clanker."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Clock it

To notice or realize something immediately.

> *"I clocked it right away."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Clout chasing

Seeking fame or attention for its own sake.

> *"Pure clout chasing."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Cooked

In serious trouble or out of options. Also "let him cook" = let someone continue doing something impressive.

> *"I forgot the presentation. I'm cooked."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Cope

Rationalizing a bad outcome.

> *"Pure cope."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Corecore

A genre of emotional, aesthetic TikTok edits that mix unrelated clips; related to “sludge content.”

> *“That corecore edit hit hard.”*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Core memory

A formative or highly memorable experience.

> *“That concert was a core memory.”*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Cortisol spike

Viral joke for moments of shock, embarrassment, or awkwardness.

> *“That meeting gave me a cortisol spike.”*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Cozymaxxing

Maximizing coziness.

> *“Cozymaxxing Friday night.”*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Crash out

Lose emotional control and react badly.

> *“Don’t crash out over a comment.”*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Crine

Deliberately misspelled “crying”; means something is extremely funny.

> *“I’m crine at this.”*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Cringe

Embarrassing or awkward.

> *"That was cringe."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Cuck

Insult implying weakness or submission.

> *"Don't be a cuck."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Cuffing season

Period (usually fall/winter) when people seek relationships.

> *"Cuffing season is here."*

D

8 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Dad lore

Stories and history about one's father, shared online.

> *"Dropping dad lore."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Datingmaxxing

Optimizing dating efforts.

> *"Datingmaxxing with a coach."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Dear Algo

A natural-language request telling a platform what you want more or less of in your feed. On Threads, “Dear Algo” / “Your Algo” steers the feed. See Chapter 3.

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Delulu

Delusional, usually used self-awarely or humorously. “Delulu is the solulu.”

> *“I’m delulu about the sequel, but it’s fun.”*

CRYPTO & MONEY

Diamond hands

Holding an asset through volatility without selling.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Doomscrolling

Endless scrolling of negative or addictive content.

> *“Caught in a doomscroll.”*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Duet

A TikTok feature that plays your video side by side with another creator’s video.

> *“Duet that.”*

CRYPTO & MONEY

DYOR

Do Your Own Research — common crypto advice.

E

3 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

EBK

Niche or obscure 2026 slang term from trend coverage.

> *"EBK moment."*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Episodic content

Serialized or story-driven content rather than one-off posts.

> *"Leaning into episodic content."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Extra

Over the top, dramatic, or excessive.

> *"She's so extra."*

F

13 TERMS

PRAISE & HYPE

Facts

Agreement; true.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Fanum tax

Taking part of someone's food.

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Finna

Fixing to / going to.

> *"I'm finna leave."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Finsta

Fake or secondary Instagram account used for more private posting.

PRAISE & HYPE

Fire

Excellent, amazing.

> *"That song is fire."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Flex

To show off.

> *"Stop flexing."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

FOMO

Fear of missing out.

> *"The FOMO from that party was real."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Frame

Maintaining control or composure in a social situation.

> *"Hold your frame."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

FRFR

For real for real — emphatic agreement.

> *"FRFR that was wild."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

FR / NGL / TBH

For real / Not gonna lie / To be honest — common truth-signaling abbreviations.

CRYPTO & MONEY

FUD

Fear, Uncertainty, Doubt.

> *"Ignore the FUD."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Future faking

Making empty promises about the future to get something in the present.

> *"Classic future faking."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

FYP

For You Page: TikTok's main algorithmic feed of recommended videos from accounts you don't follow, and its primary discovery surface.

> *"On the FYP."*

G

16 TERMS

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Gaslight

Manipulating someone into questioning their own reality or memory.

> *"Don't gaslight me."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Gatekeep

To withhold information or access (e.g., a good recommendation) from others. "Don't gatekeep."

> *"Stop gatekeeping the restaurant."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Ghost / Ghosting

Suddenly cutting off all communication without explanation.

> *"We talked for weeks and then he ghosted."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Gigachad

Extremely confident, attractive, successful archetype.

> *"Gigachad energy."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Girlboss

Ambitious, assertive woman (often used ironically now).

> *"Girlboss energy."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Glass skin

Extremely smooth, clear, luminous skin.

> *"She has glass skin."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Glazing

Excessive, over-the-top praise.

> *"Stop glazing, it was mid."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Glow up

A major positive transformation in appearance, lifestyle, or status.

> *"Her glow up is insane."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

GM

Good Morning — common casual greeting in online communities, especially crypto, NFT, Discord, and X.

> *"GM, how's everyone?"*

CRYPTO & MONEY

GN

Good Night — the counterpart to GM.

> *"GN everyone."*

PRAISE & HYPE

GOAT / Goated

Greatest of all time; top-tier.

> *"That performance was GOAT. That play was goated."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Goofy ahh

Silly, ridiculous, or dumb.

> *"That was goofy ahh."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

GRWM

Get ready with me — a common video format showing preparation.

> *"New GRWM just dropped."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Gucci

Good, fine, or excellent (from the brand).

> *"Everything is gucci."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Gyatt

Exclamation about attractiveness.

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Gymmaxxing

Prioritizing fitness.

> *"Gymmaxxing every day."*

H

7 TERMS

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Hardmaxxing

Extreme attractiveness efforts.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Has lore

Someone has a complicated or interesting past.

> *"He definitely has lore."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Healing era

A phase focused on personal recovery, growth, or self-care.

> *"In my healing era."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Hero arc

Phase of positive growth or redemption.

> *"Hero arc activated."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Hits different

Feels especially good or impactful in a particular context.

> *"This song hits different at night."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

HMU

Hit me up.

> *"HMU later."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

HODL

Hold On for Dear Life — keep holding an asset.

I

10 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

I can't do Nathan

Obscure 2026 Gen Alpha phrase that confuses adults; often left unexplained as an inside joke.

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Ick / The ick

A sudden, often minor turn-off that ends attraction.

> *"He ordered for me. Instant ick."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Iconic

Legendary or extremely memorable.

> *"That moment was iconic."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

ICYMI

In case you missed it.

REACTIONS & TEXTING

IJBOL

I just burst out laughing.

> *"IJBOL at that meme."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

I'm dead / Dead

Extremely funny.

> *"I'm dead, that was hilarious."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Influencer Fatigue

Audience weariness with paid influencer content.

> *"Full influencer fatigue."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

IRL

In real life.

REACTIONS & TEXTING

It's giving

Describes the vibe or energy something is projecting.

> *"It's giving main character energy."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

IYKYK / IFYKYK

If you know, you know — flags an inside joke or shared reference.

> *"That outfit. IYKYK."*

J

2 TERMS

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Jawmogged

Outshone specifically by jawline.

> *"Got jawmogged."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Jestermaxxing

Using humor for clout.

L

13 TERMS

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

LARP

Used to describe someone perceived as performative or living out a fantasy role.

> *"Stop LARPing."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Legendary

Exceptionally impressive or famous.

> *"Legendary performance."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Let him cook

Let them continue; they know what they're doing.

> *"Don't interrupt — let him cook."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

LFG

Let's F***ing Go — hype or excitement.

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Lock in

Focus intensely and get serious about a task.

> *"Exams next week — time to lock in."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Log off

Stop using the internet.

> *"Time to log off."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Looksmaxxing

Maximizing physical attractiveness through any available means.

> *"He's been looksmaxxing for months."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Lore

Deep personal, cultural, or historical backstory and narrative context. The 2026 Word of the Year. See Chapter 1.

> *"Wait, you used to tour with a band? You have serious lore."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Loser core

Aesthetic or vibe of intentional loser energy.

> *"Full loser core."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Love bombing

Overwhelming someone with affection early on.

> *"That was pure love bombing."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Lowkenuinely

To tell the truth or share something in a sincere, calm, laid-back way. It emerged as a 2026 search spike.

> *"Lowkenuinely, that was the best advice."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Lowkey / Highkey

Lowkey = somewhat or secretly; Highkey = openly or strongly.

> *"I'm lowkey nervous but highkey excited."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

L + ratio

Loss plus being ratio'd; insult.

M

17 TERMS

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Main character energy

Acting or living as if you are the protagonist of the story.

> *"She walked in with full main character energy."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Mald

To be mad and bald (or just extremely mad).

> *"He's malding."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Manage Topics

TikTok's control that lets people reduce how often certain topic categories (including AI-generated content) appear in the For You feed. See Chapter 3.

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Manifest

To will something into existence through belief or visualization.

> *"Manifesting a raise."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Maxxing / -maxxing

Optimizing something to the maximum; the suffix now attaches to almost anything (looksmaxxing, sleepmaxxing, auramaxxing). See Chapter 1.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Mbappé special

Playful way of saying "nothing" — someone or something has done literally nothing.

> *"He pulled a Mbappé special."*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Meat proxy

Someone who forwards or shares AI-generated content without reading or editing it.

> *"Don't be a meat proxy."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Meeksmaxxing / Meeking

Maximizing meekness or humility (less common variant).

> *"Meeksmaxxing for the bit."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Menty B

Mental breakdown (abbreviated).

> *"I'm about to have a menty B."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Mewing

Jawline exercise turned silent meme gesture.

> *"He's mewing."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Mid

Average, mediocre, or disappointing.

> *"The album was mid."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Mog / Mogging

To outshine or dominate someone in appearance or status.

> *"He was mogging the whole group."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Moneymaxxing

Focusing intensely on earning.

> *"Moneymaxxing season."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Mood

Relatable feeling.

> *"Monday morning? Mood."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

Moon

When something's price or popularity skyrockets.

> *"This is going to the moon."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Mutuals

People who follow each other.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

MySpace

Nostalgic reference to less-algorithmic, early-2000s internet.

> *"Bring back MySpace energy."*

N

5 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Nepo baby / Nepo bae

Someone whose success is largely due to famous or connected parents.

> *"Classic nepo baby."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

NGMI

Not Gonna Make It — opposite of WAGMI.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Niche

A smaller, interest-specific community or corner of the internet, worn as a badge of honor. See Chapter 1.

> *"My niche."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

No thoughts head empty

Mind blank, often used humorously.

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

NPC

Non-player character; someone who seems to lack independent thought or just follows trends.

> *"Total NPC behavior in the comments."*

O

6 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Ohio

Weird, chaotic, or surreal (Ohio memes).

> *"That's so Ohio."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Oneitis

Obsessive fixation on one person.

> *"He has oneitis."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

OOMF

One of my followers.

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

OOTD

Outfit of the day.

> *"Today's OOTD is giving."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Orbiters

People who hover around someone hoping for attention.

> *"He has orbiters."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Orbiting

Liking posts and watching stories without direct messaging.

> *"He's been orbiting."*

P

8 TERMS

CRYPTO & MONEY

Paper hands

Selling too early out of fear.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Parasocial

One-sided relationship with a public figure.

> *"Parasocial behavior."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Period / Periodt

End of discussion; emphatic finality.

> *"She's the best, periodt."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Pick-me

Someone who seeks validation by putting others down or trying to be chosen.

> *"Stop being a pick-me."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Plot twist

Unexpected turn of events.

> *"Total plot twist."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Polyester

Figurative for anything cheap, synthetic, or over-polished (Gen Z sustainability/content backlash).

> *"That campaign is pure polyester."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

POV

Point of view; on TikTok often used to set up a scene the viewer should imagine themselves in.

> *"POV: you just got the news."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Proteinmaxxing

Maximizing protein intake.

> *"Proteinmaxxing breakfast."*

Q

1 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Quiet on the creek

Be quiet or keep something to yourself.

> *"Quiet on the creek about the surprise."*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

R

12 TERMS

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Rage bait

Content engineered specifically to provoke anger and engagement.

> *"Classic rage bait."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Ratio

When a reply or quote gets more engagement than the original post (often as a dunk).

> *"You got ratio'd."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Realizing your friend has lore

Trend of discovering unexpected depth in someone's history.

> *"Just realized my friend has lore."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Receipts

Proof or evidence of something said or done.

> *"Show the receipts."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Red flag / Green flag

Warning signs versus positive indicators, especially in dating.

> *"Huge red flag."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Redpilled

Having one's eyes opened to an uncomfortable truth.

> *"He got redpilled."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Reels

Instagram's short, vertical, full-screen videos, recommended to non-followers; its primary growth format.

> *"New Reel."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Rent free

Something that occupies your mind constantly without permission.

> *"That song is living rent free in my head."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Rizz

Charisma, especially romantic or flirting skill. From "charisma." "Rizz someone up" = flirt.

> *"He's got unspoken rizz."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Rizzler

Person with strong rizz.

> *"He's a rizzler."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Roman Empire

Something random that you think about every single day.

> *"That's my Roman Empire."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

Rug pull

Scam where creators abandon a project and take the money.

> *"Classic rug pull."*

S

31 TERMS

PRAISE & HYPE

Say less

Got it; no further explanation needed.

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Scuba

Something or someone that stinks (often with a nose-holding gesture).

> *"That take is scuba."*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Seethe

To be quietly angry or bitter.

> *"They're seething."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Sending me

Something is extremely funny or overwhelming.

> *"This comment is sending me."*

CRYPTO & MONEY

Ser

Playful "sir".

> *"Yes ser."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Serving

Looking great or delivering a strong look/performance.

> *"Serving looks today."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Shade

Subtle insult or criticism.

> *"She threw shade."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

PRAISE & HYPE

Sheesh

Expression of surprise, impressiveness, or disbelief.

> *"Sheesh, that fit is crazy."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Shill

To promote something aggressively, often for personal gain.

> *"Stop shilling."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Shorts

YouTube's short vertical video format.

> *"New YouTube Short."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Side eye

Judgmental or suspicious look.

> *"Gave him the side eye."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Sigma

Lone-wolf, self-sufficient archetype; often ironic.

> *"Full sigma energy."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Simp

Someone who does too much for a crush or person they're into.

> *"Stop simping."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Situationship

Ambiguous romantic connection that isn't a full relationship.

> *"Stuck in a situationship."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Skibidi

Nonsense meme term from Skibidi Toilet videos; pure brainrot energy.

> *"Skibidi toilet references everywhere."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Skincaremaxxing

Intensive skincare routine.

> *"Full skincaremaxxing."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Slaps

Sounds or is extremely good (especially music).

> *"This track slaps."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Slay

To do something impressively well; to look or perform amazingly.

> *"You slayed that interview."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Sleepmaxxing

Optimizing sleep.

> *"Sleepmaxxing hard."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Slop / AI slop

Low-quality, mass-produced content generated largely by AI with little human judgment, originality, or care. See Chapter 1.

> *"The entire Explore page is slop today."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Slow fade

Gradually reducing contact instead of abrupt ghosting.

> *"It was a slow fade."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

SMH

Shaking my head.

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Socialmaxxing

Actively improving social skills or status.

> *"Socialmaxxing this semester."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Soft launch / Hard launch

Soft launch = discreetly introducing a relationship or project. Hard launch = a bold, public announcement of it.

> *"They're soft-launching the relationship."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Softmaxxing

Gentle glow-up efforts.

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Soyboy

Insult for a soft or unmasculine man.

> *"Stop being a soyboy."*

DEROGATORY · USE WITH CARE

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Stan

Intense fan; also used as a verb.

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Statusmaxxing

Maximizing social status.

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Stitch

A TikTok feature: clip a few seconds of another creator's video and play it before your own response.

> *"Stitch this."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Sunday scaries

Anxiety or dread about the upcoming work/school week that hits on Sunday.

> *"The Sunday scaries are real."*

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Sus

Suspicious or sketchy.

> *"That excuse is sus."*

T

11 TERMS

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Talking stage

Early phase of flirting/texting before anything official.

> *"We're just in the talking stage."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Tea

Gossip or the truth about a situation.

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Terminally online

Even more extreme version of chronically online.

REACTIONS & TEXTING

TFW

That feeling when.

> *"TFW the Wi-Fi drops."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

That's so AI

Insult for something fake, low-quality, or obviously machine-generated.

> *"That photo is so AI."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Thirst trap

Post designed to attract sexual attention.

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Thirsty

Desperately seeking attention or validation.

> *"So thirsty."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Thread

A chain of connected posts by one user.

> *"Long thread."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

TLPUR

Obscure TikTok slang that adults searched heavily in 2026.

> *"What does TLPUR mean?"*

EMERGING · THIN SOURCING

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Tokenmaxxing

Maximizing AI token use.

> *"Tokenmaxxing at work."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Touch grass

Advice to log off and reconnect with the real world.

> *"You've been online for six hours. Touch grass."*

U

4 TERMS

PUT-DOWNS & SHADE

Unc

Short for uncle; used to call someone out for acting old or out of touch.

> *"Unc, that reference is from 2019."*

PRAISE & HYPE

Understood the assignment

Did exactly what was needed, perfectly.

> *"She understood the assignment."*

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Unhinged

Chaotic, wild, or deliberately unpolished energy, frequently applied to brand voice. See Chapter 1.

> *"That was unhinged."*

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Unspoken rizz

Charisma shown through actions, not words.

> *"He has unspoken rizz."*

V

3 TERMS

PRAISE & HYPE

Valid

Legitimate, acceptable, or understandable.

REACTIONS & TEXTING

Vibe / Vibe check

Mood or atmosphere; checking someone's energy.

> *"He failed the vibe check."*

MINDSET & LIFESTYLE

Villain arc

Phase of embracing negative or rebellious energy.

> *"Entering my villain arc."*

W

7 TERMS

CRYPTO & MONEY

WAGMI

We're All Gonna Make It — optimistic crypto/community phrase.

CRYPTO & MONEY

Wen

Playful misspelling of "when" (especially "wen moon").

> *"Wen moon?"*

PRAISE & HYPE

Werk / Work

To perform or serve looks exceptionally (ballroom origin).

> *"Werk that look."*

ROOTS IN AAVE & BALLROOM CULTURE

CRYPTO & MONEY

Whale

Someone who holds a very large amount of an asset.

> *"A whale just bought."*

PRAISE & HYPE

W / L

Win / Loss. A W is a victory or positive outcome.

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

W rizz / L rizz

Good or bad flirting energy.

> *"That's W rizz."*

REACTIONS & TEXTING

WYD

What (are) you doing?

> *"WYD tonight?"*

Y

2 TERMS

INTERNET CULTURE & MEMES

Yap

To talk a lot, often excessively. Variants include yappuccino.

> *"She yapped for twenty minutes."*

PLATFORMS & ALGORITHMS

Your Algorithm

A feed-control tool that shows the topics tied to your account and lets you add or remove interests. Instagram's version covers Reels, Explore and Feed; Facebook's is a natural-language tool. See Chapter 3.

Z

2 TERMS

DATING & RELATIONSHIPS

Zombieing

Reappearing after ghosting, as if nothing happened.

> *"Classic zombieing."*

MAXXING & GLOW-UPS

Zoomer Perm

Specific younger-generation hairstyle or look.

> *"Rocking the Zoomer Perm."*

CHAPTER

03

Platform Features, Formats & Algorithm Controls

TikTok, Instagram, X, Threads and the new steering tools

Most major platforms have converged on vertical short-form video, yet each retains distinctive tools. 2026 has also brought a wave of user-facing algorithm controls that let people tell platforms what they want to see in natural language or via topic sliders.

TikTok

- **For You Page (FYP)** — The main algorithmic feed of recommended videos from accounts you do not follow. The primary discovery surface.
- **Stitch** — Clip a few seconds of another creator's video and play it before your own response.
- **Duet** — Play your video side-by-side with another creator's video.
- **Stories** — 24-hour ephemeral updates.
- **Manage Topics** — User control (sliders) that lets people reduce the frequency of certain topic categories in the For You feed, including AI-generated content options.

Instagram

- **Reels** — Short vertical full-screen videos recommended to non-followers. Primary growth format.
- **Stories** — 24-hour full-screen updates for existing followers. Can be saved as Highlights.
- **Close Friends** — A restricted list that sees Stories marked with a green ring.
- **Notes** — Short text updates shown above the inbox for 24 hours.
- **Carousel** — Multi-image or multi-video post that users swipe through.
- **Collab post** — A post co-authored by multiple accounts.
- **Repost** — Native button to share someone else's public post or Reel with credit.

- **Your Algorithm** — Control panel (available since late 2025/2026) that shows topics associated with your account and lets you add or remove interests across Reels, Explore, and Feed.
- **Instants** — Unedited in-the-moment photos shared only to Close Friends or mutuals (launched 2026).

X (formerly Twitter), Threads & Others

- **Post / Repost** — The current names for what were once tweets and retweets on X.
- **Quote post** — Share someone else's post with your own commentary on top.
- **Thread** — A chain of connected posts by one user.
- **Community Notes** — Crowdsourced context added to posts on X.
- **Threads** — Meta's text-based app. Features include Dear Algo / Your Algo for steering the feed.
- **Shorts** — YouTube's short vertical video format.
- **Your Algorithm (Facebook)** — Natural-language tool (rolled out October 2026) that lets users describe what they want more or less of in Feed and Reels.

Cross-platform concepts

- **Algorithm** — The ranking system that decides what each user sees. Different surfaces often have distinct algorithms.
- **Shadowban** — Informal term for a platform quietly limiting the reach of an account's content without an official notification.
- **Feed** — The scrolling stream of content.
- **Link in bio** — The clickable URL in a profile, used because many platforms do not allow links in captions.
- **Explore page** — Instagram's personalized discovery grid of recommended content.

CHAPTER

04

Metrics, Marketing, Content Concepts & Algospeak

The vocabulary of reach, hooks and filters

Key metrics

- **Engagement** — Actions taken on content: likes, comments, shares, saves, clicks.
- **Engagement rate** — Interactions divided by an audience figure (reach, followers, or views).
- **Impressions vs Views** — Impressions count how often content was shown (including repeats). Many platforms now emphasize views.
- **Reach** — Unique people who saw the content.
- **CTR (Click-through rate)** — Percentage of impressions that produced a click.
- **CPM** — Cost per mille (cost per thousand impressions) for advertising.
- **Hook** — The opening seconds or first line designed to stop the scroll.
- **CTA (Call to action)** — Explicit instruction telling the viewer what to do next.
- **KPI** — Key performance indicator tied to a business goal.

Content & creator concepts

- **Engagement bait** — Posts that explicitly ask for likes, comments, or shares to game distribution. Often limited by platform policies.
- **Dark social** — Sharing that happens in private channels (DMs, messaging apps) and is hard to track.
- **Influencer / Creator / Digital creator** — Someone whose recommendations or original content influence others.
- **KOL** — Key opinion leader.
- **Boosted post** — An organic post that is paid to reach more people.
- **Cross-posting** — Publishing the same (or adapted) content across multiple platforms.
- **Content calendar** — A planned schedule of posts.

- **Brand voice** — The consistent personality a brand uses in its writing and content.

Algospeak

Algospeak is the practice of distorting language so that platforms do not flag or suppress content. Common substitutions include:

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
unalive	die / suicide / kill
seggs	sex
corn	porn
creative misspellings & emojis	used to evade keyword filters

The practice shows how platform rules actively shape everyday vocabulary. Creators and users adapt language before traditional dictionaries do. Understanding algospeak helps both decode comments and avoid unintended suppression of legitimate content.

CHAPTER

05

Origins, Context & Staying Current

Where the words come from, and how to keep up

A large share of the most resilient social-media slang has roots in African American Vernacular English and in Black and Latino ballroom culture. Terms such as slay, werk, tea, shade, no cap, bussin, and period circulated in those communities for years or decades before TikTok popularized them among wider audiences. Gaming culture contributed mechanics language (farming, NPC, W/L). Newer nonsense terms (skibidi, 6-7) are often pure meme products with little deeper origin.

Using the language well means understanding both the current definition and the history. Appropriation without credit is a frequent criticism when terms move from marginalized communities into mainstream marketing. Tone and context also matter: many terms are ironic or playful, and the same word can be a compliment or a dig depending on delivery.

Credit where it is due

Terms the source material traces to AAVE and Black and Latino ballroom culture:

slay werk tea shade no cap bussin period

How to stay current in a fast-moving landscape

Language on social platforms turns over quickly. Follow accounts and creators that explain trends in real time, watch comment sections (they often invent or refine terms), and check major platforms' own documentation and newsrooms for feature changes. Glossaries maintained by practitioners and annual "word of the year" analyses from social listening companies are useful checkpoints. Expect new terms every few months; the ones that stick usually describe a lasting behavior, feeling, or platform constraint.

User-controlled algorithm tools (Your Algorithm, Manage Topics, Dear Algo) are themselves becoming part of the vocabulary. Knowing how

people can now steer feeds changes how creators think about discoverability and how audiences experience platforms.

Conclusion

The vocabulary of 2026 social media mixes deep cultural inheritance, platform constraints, meme energy, and genuine shifts in what audiences want: more lore, less slop, smaller niches, occasional unhinged authenticity, and greater control over their own feeds. Mastering a few dozen core terms makes feeds, comments, and group chats far more legible. The language will keep evolving; the underlying drivers — speed, recognition, community, resistance to low-effort content, and the desire for narrative — are likely to remain.

Sources & notes

Sources drawn from public reporting and platform documentation as of October 2026, including Sprout Social's word-of-the-year analysis, practitioner glossaries (e.g., Outfeed AI), Preply slang trend data, Meta and TikTok announcements on algorithm controls, and contemporary coverage of aura farming, looksmaxxing, algospeak, and related cultural phenomena. Definitions are synthesized for practical use and may continue to shift.

Browse by Theme

Every term in the dictionary, grouped by what it is about. Look the word up in Chapter 2 or the A–Z Index.

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